

7 Ways to Monitor Your Website



Introduction

Your website is your digital storefront, whether you're running a business, managing a blog, or promoting a personal project. It works for you 24/7, even when you're not looking. But what happens when it goes down, slows to a crawl, or gets hit by an unexpected change?

This guide will walk you through seven essential ways to monitor your website so you can stay ahead of issues, protect your online presence, and ensure everything's running smoothly.

We will explore

- 01** Uptime monitoring
- 02** SSL monitoring
- 03** Domain expiration monitoring
- 04** DNS change monitoring
- 05** Visual change monitoring
- 06** Page speed monitoring
- 07** Site health reporting



01 Uptime monitoring

Imagine potential customers visiting your website, only to find it's offline. Every minute of downtime can mean lost revenue, reduced trust, and frustrated users. Uptime monitoring ensures this doesn't happen to your business.

Website monitoring is the practice of regularly checking your site for issues like downtime, security problems, and performance drops, before they affect your users.

Website downtime can be caused by five factors:

1. **Human error** - Around 40% of all significant website outages over the previous three years have been related to human errors.
2. **Cyberattacks** - In 2024, 40% of small businesses reported some form of a cyber attack.
3. **Traffic spikes** - Whilst every business wants to be successful, as your business develops it puts more strain on your hosting server to cope with surges in traffic.
4. **Software issues** - Outdated or incompatible software can cause slow or sudden deteriorations or loss of a website.
5. **Expired domains or SSL certificates** - Your domain and your SSL certificate will require regular renewal. If they are allowed to expire without renewal then your website will become unavailable very suddenly.

How can UpWatch help?

One of the seven website monitoring services we include in all of our plans is uptime monitoring. We will check regularly to see if your website is loading across multiple continents.

Unlike other website uptime monitoring services, we use three independent monitors to triple-verify your uptime. One monitor can lead to false reports of uptime or downtime. With three monitors running simultaneously, we can provide near-perfect accuracy in our reporting. We will only worry you with a report of downtime when it is 100% certain.

02 SSL monitoring

A secure sockets layer (SSL) is a digital document that works as a certificate to confirm the identity of a website and to make the connection between the user and the website more secure and private.

Ever since 2014, it has been required for websites to have an SSL certificate to prevent the website from being hidden in the Google rankings, to be marked as 'not secure' or, worst of all, for the website to not load at all or for anti-virus software to actively block your website.

For the safety, security, and overall functioning of your website, you need an SSL certificate that is active, valid and has not expired.

As important as SSL certificates are, much like domains, they do expire. In fact, most providers will only offer one that lasts for 90 days. They should auto-renew, but that is no guarantee and you cannot risk any interruption.

You have probably already seen the consequences of an SSL certificate being left to expire. Essentially, visitors will encounter warnings indicating that the connection is not private or secure. Some anti-virus providers also block access to unsecure websites.

How can UpWatch help?

Our monitoring will check the expiration date of your SSL certificate and notify you if it is due to expire soon.

You choose how much notice we give you. With our higher Premium level, you will be notified 30 days before the certificate expires. 30 days is around the point that most SSL certificate providers will auto-renew your certificate, so we will let you know as soon as the auto-renew has failed.

While your certificate should auto-renew, we act as a fail-safe to let you know if something unexpected has happened and to help you manually renew your SSL certificate long before it expires and your website becomes unavailable or unsecure for visitors.

03

Domain expiration monitoring

Your website's domain is the address of your business's website. Without it, there is no website. Most domain providers offer automatic domain renewal, so your domain will be paid for automatically when it reaches the end of the one, two, three, etc. year period you paid for when you purchased it.

However, some providers require you to turn on auto-renews, sometimes the auto-renewal fails or sometimes the payment card held by the provider has expired or has insufficient funds. All of these factors can lead to a situation where very suddenly your website no longer has an address.

Luckily, most domain providers will offer you a grace period after expiration and make it as easy as possible for you to renew and as hard as possible for you to end up with your domain completely expiring and your website going offline as a result.

Sometimes, a domain is purchased for a company via the web agency they used to build their first website. It is important for you to know who owns the domain and who has access to renew the domain. Do not assume it will auto-renew and never assume it's someone else's responsibility.

How can UpWatch help?

Our domain monitoring service checks when your domain is due to expire and alerts you in advance.

You choose how long before the end date that you are alerted. At the top level, we will let you know 30 days before.

Your provider should also notify you, but if they don't or if the auto-renewal fails, we will keep you notified up to the point that it expires.

04 DNS change monitoring

Your DNS records act like a signpost. When a visitor types in your website's address, the DNS records tell the user's browser which hosting server to visit to find the website. It also tells email providers where to find your email accounts, it also helps to verify your domain and improve the deliverability of your sent emails. Your DNS records are the technical backbone to the whole digital aspect of your business.

You will occasionally need to make changes to your DNS records, maybe when changing hosts or when a new service needs you to authenticate your domain. Either by accident or by maliciousness, DNS changes can happen that affect or bring down your website and/or email accounts.

You need to know both when changes happen that you were not expecting and what the records were before the change. This information together helps you quickly rectify the situation.

Sometimes, changes you have made to your DNS records can be undone by DNS providers or domain providers when the changes fail to save or get rolled back. It is often quite hard to spot when a website's downtime is related to DNS changes.

How can UpWatch help?

Our DNS change monitoring will check periodically for any alterations to your records. The package you choose determines how often the records are checked. At the top level, they are checked every 24 hours.

If any changes are noted, we will let you know that a record has been altered and the changes seen. We can also assess any impact of the change, depending on the type of change noticed.

As an extra service, we can help you keep a log of your DNS records so that you always have a benchmark to refer to if you feel something is not correct.

05

Visual change monitoring

In the modern world of business, your website is at the core of people's understanding of your business. It tells people what you do, how you do it, who it is aimed at and how they can get in touch or become a customer.

Unexpected or incorrect changes to the website, malicious activities and software or server errors can all harm the impression your website gives to visitors. Other website monitoring tools cannot spot these sorts of issues, but visual change monitoring can!

When you first enrol your website in a visual change monitor it scans your website and takes a screenshot. Then, when the website is periodically monitored, it takes a new screenshot and compares the two. If there is around a 20% difference, and you can tweak this threshold, then it will send out an alert.

There are many reasons why you might need visual change monitoring

1. **Website has been hacked** - Your website can be altered after a hack to run adverts for adult content or gambling sites, for instance.
2. **Domain or DNS changes** - When your website's domain expires or the nameservers are changed it can revert to the domain provider's 'parked page'.
3. **Broken images** - By accidentally deleting an image in your CMS you can break images on the website.
4. **Missing buttons** - Links to contact pages, pricing pages or product pages are crucial to convert visitors. You don't want them disappearing!

How can UpWatch help?

Our visual change monitoring works in conjunction with our other monitors. Even when the uptime monitor says the site is working, the visual change monitor can look for anything visual that is unexpected.

06 Page speed monitoring

It is a fundamental, basic expectation of both your customers and Google's ranking bots that your website will load in under 2 seconds. Anything more than 3 seconds will see a 53% likelihood that the user will leave and your website's ranking will drop.

There are many reasons why a website would load slowly. Factors such as the hosting, the underlying software and the content on the page will have an effect. These factors, though, will always affect the loading time of the website.

Page speed monitoring is about the sudden changes to your loading time. If your website usually takes 3 seconds to load, if one day it takes 5 seconds, something has happened that needs correcting. It could be due to software or hosting issues, it could be due to malicious factors, whatever it is, it's good to know so it can be remedied.

There are plenty of websites that you can use to take a one-off analysis of your website's uptime. However, these rely upon you choosing to run them and are often used after someone already has a feeling something isn't optimal with their website.

How can UpWatch help?

Our page speed monitoring will periodically load your website and check the time it takes against the benchmark it stored the last time it loaded. The package you choose determines how often the website is monitored. At the top level, your website is monitored every 24 hours.

If there is a 20% change in the loading time of your website, you will be alerted. A sudden 20% drop could mean your site has been affected by a large image, faulty script, or plugin issue. This could be a minor issue that resolves itself the next day, or it could be the start of something significant.

If you receive a report that your website is slower than usual, but are not sure why, we can also help you work through the incident and find out the root cause and list any steps you or any agency you work with could take to improve the loading time.

07 Site health reporting

Site health reporting is all about looking for basic coding and functionality factors that will affect the user experience and the SEO ranking of your website.

Running a periodic analysis of your website helps to look for anything deteriorating or any small, near-imperceptible factors that are making your website less effective. It also helps you, your employees and any agency you're working with creating a clear 'to-do' list of improvements.

Here are seven ways you can assess the health of your website:

1. **Site health score** - A simple percentage score to represent the overall health.
2. **Critical issues or warnings** - Anything affecting that site health score.
3. **Broken links** - If any of the links on your website no longer work.
4. **Titles and descriptions** - If the core SEO content of your site needs addressing.
5. **All website links** - An overview of all internal and external links.
6. **Slow or missing images** - If any images on your website are broken or slow to load.
7. **SEO keywords** - Your ranking position of your website against keywords.

How can UpWatch help?

We provide regular site health reports. Depending on the package you choose, you can get monthly, fortnightly or weekly reports covering all seven areas above. This can act as a clear indication into the overall health and wellbeing of your website.

The reports are helpful not only for technical teams, but also for non-technical business owners.

If the report uncovers areas of concern, but you are not sure what they mean or how you can remedy them, we can offer one-to-one help and advice to assist you in fixing any issues on your website.

Want to get in touch?

If you want to find out more about UpWatch and how we can help you prevent or reduce website downtime, you can find out more on our website or drop us an email.



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